Without being specific about Trotty, you can't mollycoddle anyone in Test cricket.

I get on really well with the bloke. I love him to bits. I didn't spot the warning signs early enough. I should have knocked on his door and talked through everything in as much detail as he could stand. Instead, I relied on those passing, inconsequential conversations that make up so much of the day.

'You all right, Trotty?'

'Yeah, yeah, good. Just battling a few things.'

He always battled things. That's what made him so good, his OCD, his single-minded pursuit of brilliance. Obsessed by the minutiae of the game, he would measure his pads to the millimetre. He was visibly driven to put in a performance for himself, his parents, his team. His determination and desire were as ferocious as his demons. His autobiography, *Unguarded* , which revealed relentless self-imposed pressure to please his mum and dad, makes sobering reading.

I prefer to remember our classic unbeaten partnership of 329 in Brisbane, three years earlier. Andrew Strauss had made 110 in our opening stand of 188. Trotty and I were similar in terms of the deliberation of our approach, but he was meticulous beyond reason. He loved the cadence of our batting until we declared just before tea on the final day.

We were 517–1. That was one hell of an achievement. The locals had voted with their feet, so the Gabba was colonized by the Barmy Army. One of the tabloid boys got a bit overexcited, compared it to England's World Cup win in 1966, and suggested that Trotty and I 'didn't just occupy the crease – they built holiday homes on it'. Even Graham Gooch wandered out to take a photograph of the scoreboard for posterity.

Strauss 110. Trott 135. Cook 235. England 517. Magic numbers.

Like most of us, Trotty learned on the job. He rarely drank, unless it was in celebration at the end of a series, when he gave it a little nudge. He realized, very quickly, very early in his career, that his lifestyle had to be tailored to his ambitions as an elite professional.

There is a sharp dividing line between the pressure you put on yourself to excel and the pressure you put on yourself to be a good husband, father and teammate. Is there something about cricket, the long hours and extended absence from home, that makes suppressing things that bit more damaging? Probably.